In 1989 socialism was over as a project for a better future which previously had inspired (and also disappointed) many generations. The new generations after active socialism were worse off; they had no alternative. As Margaret Thatcher triumphantly declared: 'There is no alternative beyond the neoliberal promise of "freedom, democracy, wealth".' This was true only of a happy minority of the world population, not for the majority. History came to an end.

The last decade of the 20th century therefore became a period of the 'unipolar moment' of the US, of global governance under the 'benign' leadership of the USA and of new conflicts, some of them, like the wars in former Yugoslavia, in Afghanistan or in Iraq, very brutal ones. The end of this period came abruptly on 11 September 2001. In its aftermath, the consequences, drawn by the Bush administration in responding to the attack on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon, reshaped the world. The unipolar moment of a benign hegemon changed into the domination of the world by a predatory hegemon: the war on terror dragged the world into a series of military conflicts in many regions. It transformed the political landscape of the Near and Middle East, including parts of Central Asia, of Africa and of the former Soviet Union.

Moreover, the political chaos has been enforced by economic factors. The monetary and fiscal policy of the USA after 2001 triggered the global financial crisis which broke out in 2007/2008 and which has since then affected the second power-house of the capitalist world system, the European Union. The massive trade deficit of the USA has an even longer history. It is destabilising the capitalist world system and reshaping the global political power structure.

**Birth and baptism of BRICS**

This became obvious at the G8 summit of Heiligendamm (Germany) in 2007 when the G8 were forced to open their elitist meeting and to accept some newcomers, Brazil, India, China and South Africa, as partners. They treated the BRICS – Russia already was a member of the G8 – as subaltern partners but they had to take their new political importance into consideration, for the traditional G8 was not able to find a solution to global imbalances, caused by the trade deficit of the USA and the resulting exploding external debt of the superpower, without including the new creditor countries in a political solution. This was especially true for China, but also for the other BRICS countries. Their trade surpluses and the resulting credit position in financial markets made the solution to the crisis of the global economic and financial system only viable by including the new powers in an agreement. The political leaders of the BRICS still had the experience of the debt crisis of the Third World in the 1980s in mind,